

Seeds of Discord

CHRONOLOGY

1961: Gurjars made the first concerted effort to get into the ST list.

1976: Held rally in Bari, Dholpur, and made a strong plea to the Centre.

1981: Centre sought state opinion but Congress government rejected the Gurjar claim.

1999: NDA government sought status on Gurjars from Congress government which it did not send.

2003-2007: Bainsla came into picture, began work on Gurjar demand and brought media from Delhi. Railway tracks and signals broken at Hindon



in first major violence.

May 29, 2007: Attempt to block Jaipur-Agra highway at Patauli turned violent. Fifteen died.

May 30-June 3: Toll reached 25 as violence and arson spread. Police retreated.

June 4: Raje and Bainsla signed agreement but Gurjars felt Bainsla let them down.

June 27: Chopra committee set up to look into demand for ST status and suggest ways for upliftment.

July-November: Gurjars continued agitations as

well as talks.

December 17: Committee did not recommend ST status but agreed for special treatment.

January 17, 2008: State wrote to Centre for 6 per cent reservation for denotified tribes.

May 8: Raje announced Rs 282 crore package for Gurjar-dominated backward areas.

May 18: Bainsla rejected package and gave call for rail roko.

May 23: One policeman and 16 Gurjars killed. Violence spreads.

maintained that they had done their best for the community. Little wonder then that Bainsla rejected the package straight away and gave a call for rail roko on May 18, handing out a five-day ultimatum to the state to meet their demands. The Government tried engaging him in discussions but these were mostly telephonic queries, seeking to ensure that the agitation would be peaceful. Home Minister Gulab Chand Kataria and senior officials spoke to Bainsla who assured them the agitation would not be violent.

The agitation soon turned into a battle which eventually left 39 dead, scores injured and vast areas of the state under a bloody siege. The scene soon resembled a state of civil war, with the army called in to surround Gurjar dominated villages to seal them off from the rest of the state and to starve them into submission. It didn't work. The agitation has not only spread to neighbouring states, but the Gurjars have been joined by their womenfolk and seem to have plenty of food supplies to combat the siege. They are also becoming increasingly militant. In the initial stages, a policeman was hacked to death and entire highways blocked, railway lines uprooted and vehicles set on fire. At the centre of the storm, Bainsla sits alongside the bodies of slain Gurjars, refusing to allow them to be removed, a macabre but potent reminder that the agitation will not peter out on the back of false promises.

The other person close to the centre of the storm, Raje, displays a sense of helplessness. "I am shocked and puzzled," she says, adding, "We—the Government and Bainsla—have walked a long distance together but now are

back at the point from where we began." In retrospect, many politicians feel that she could have avoided the current situation by making a one-line recommendation to the Centre for the grant of ST status to the community. The Centre would then have asked for a detailed report and the state could have taken its time over that—something which former Congress chief minister Ashok Gehlot had done. Instead, she was more worried about a backlash from the powerful Meena community which controls more than 30 seats in the 200 member Assembly. The Gurjars have less than 10. The Meenas have always been perceived as being more aggressive than the Gurjars and also consider themselves superior. They would strongly resent the Gurjars being given the same tribal status they enjoy. This prompted Raje to take the middle path by giving the Gurjars economic sops but this failed to dilute their ST demand. Raje, however, insists that she "is still working towards the best solution".

That may be too little too late. Bainsla continues to repeat his now famous line: "We want *'chitthi'*." The *'chitthi'* means a letter from the state Government recommending ST status for the Gurjars to the Centre. "This is the first stage of the process. Let them write just a one-line recommendation and if the Centre dithers, we will deal with them," Bainsla has maintained. Their position is that the Chopra committee failed in not looking at political aspirations. The Jat demand for OBC status had arisen from the fact that their grassroots leadership was thrown out of panchayats and local bodies as seats were reserved for OBCs. Similarly, the Gurjars feel that ST status

The state government wrongly believed that Bainsla's authority had been undermined and the Gurjars placated.